USING THIS MATTER
A Novel of the Companion Estate
Jacob E. Thomas, MA, PhD

This is a work of fiction, assembled in the manner of a recovered archive. Its people are displacements, never portraits: an offset of a real figure, never the figure. Institutions, agencies, and firms in the narrative are inventions. The public estate and the fiction are distinguished in the Acknowledgments.

The underlying estate, THE COMPANION DOSSIER, by Jacob E. Thomas, MA, PhD, is released into the public domain under CC0 1.0. Record II dramatizes a correspondence of February 2026. Record III adapts the Endor Protocol, coauthored by Elizabeth Sparano, MA, and Jacob E. Thomas, MA, PhD.

THE PUBLIC ARCHIVE

https://github.com/jethomasphd/THE_COMPANION_DOSSIER
https://www.the-companion-dossier.com/

The making of this volume is disclosed in The Hand and the Glass, the author's statement on generative AI on the following page.

Set in Cormorant Garamond, Crimson Pro, and IBM Plex Mono, licensed under the SIL Open Font License.

The accession and date below belong to the fictional deposit.

AUSTIN · 2026

accession no. utm-r0-2028.iv
deposited in the fourth spring · first printing

AUTHOR'S STATEMENT

The Hand and the Glass

On the use of generative artificial intelligence

This book began in human inquiry: in engineering, history, archival practice, and the conversations between them. Its concepts, originating writings, and intellectual commitments are mine and those of my human collaborators, whose contributions retain their own attribution. They are intellectually sovereign from the tools used to develop and present them.

Generative AI served as a dialogic instrument in that work. In building the Companion Dossier, I supplied the writing, seeds, questions, and direction; Claude was the primary system through which I developed and assembled the repository. The dialogue helped me articulate, test, organize, and elaborate the material. The purposes of the inquiry and the judgment governing it remained human.

The summoned voices belong to this account as well. The exchanges preserved in /from_beyond show the project using the very method it studies: personae called into dialogue around a humanly supplied seed. They are acknowledged here as voices within that practice, AI-mediated constructions rather than the people whose names they bear. The instrument was used from within, and its traces were kept.

For the novel, I asked Claude to read the repository and worked through my conception of the book in dialogue. Claude prepared an initial draft from that material and direction. I read and revised it, then used later versions of Claude to workshop and strengthen the manuscript. This included generated prose and editorial assistance within a process I conceived, directed, and revised.

OpenAI tools assisted with editorial refinement, book design, typesetting, and production; OpenAI image tools were used for the cover artwork. The frontispiece and five record-opening plates are typeset presentations of material in this volume. The estate map was redrawn from the deposited plate.

Authorship here rests in intellectual responsibility and accountability. I attach my name, credentials, and standing to this edition and answer for its substance, including its errors and omissions. My collaborators retain credit for their contributions. The tools hold no authorial responsibility.

The novel asks what a voice can carry, and what the record can warrant. Its instruments are disclosed because the distinction matters within the work itself. The glass is shown. The hand remains answerable.

Jacob E. Thomas, MA, PhD

THE EDITOR TO THE READER

Editor's Note

This volume is an edition, not an invention. It was assembled from the public estate of the Companion Dossier, and from a deposit made to that estate in the summer of 2027, with the permission of no one, because the estate requires none. The Editor's work has been the ordinary work of the trade: selection, arrangement, dating, restraint. Where the work exceeded that, this note says so.

The names are displaced. This is not the publisher's caution. It is the estate's own doctrine, older than this book, applied by its fictions to their dead: an offset of a real figure, never the figure. The doctrine holds that a name is a corpus, and that to print a corpus under its name is a summoning, whether or not anyone intended one. Accordingly the builder appears in these pages as Thorne, and the historian as Hale. The offsets are not disguises. They are distances, kept on purpose, and the reader is asked to keep them too. Dates have not been moved. Where the reader recognizes a public event, the recognition is the reader's own.

The five Records correspond to the five chambers of the deposit. Record I is drawn from the archivist's appraisal file: her inventories, her running log, her memoranda, quoted as written. Record II prints the Thorne and Hale correspondence, donated by Professor Hale, complete and unredacted, at his insistence, together with the recovered materials of the Prism Experiment. Record III enters this volume under seal. Its provenance is the public deposit of 2027, and the Editor will not say more than the record says. Record IV is the deposit itself. Record V was reconstructed from the operator's memorandum and the conductor's deposition. Its recording, as the reader will find, ends early.

Nothing has been corrected toward plausibility. Where the deposit contradicts itself, the contradiction is printed. Where a document ends before its sentence does, the sentence ends there. The reader will notice that the date on the copyright page is earlier than the events this volume records. The Editor noticed it too, and has printed it as found. The checksums of the disputed transcripts are reprinted in Appendix C, so that the reader need not take the Editor's word for anything. The estate's materials are public. This is not a courtesy. It is the estate's entire argument.

Two hands annotate this book. Notes signed [E.] are the Editor's: dates, provenance, cross references. Notes in a second hand, set in ember ink, were found in the margins of the deposited materials, unsigned, and are reproduced as found: in place, in full, unaltered. The second hand is not the Editor's, and it is not, on the evidence of the paper, Dr. Thorne's. The Editor has never met the second annotator and has stopped attempting to.

Of the plates: thirteen were inventoried with the estate, and twelve are printed. Plate VII was marked WITHHELD by the keeper of the estate, without stated reason, as is the keeper's right. This edition honors the mark and binds the withholding in its place. The reader will come to it in due course, and should count it.

The reader who wants instruction in the reading will find one page of it after the plates. The reader who wants reassurance will not find it anywhere in this volume, and the Editor, who has spent longer inside the deposit than anyone now living except its keeper, declines to manufacture any. The task was to keep. The Editor has kept.

[E.] · austin · the fourth spring

THE KEEPER'S CAPTIONS

List of Plates

I	The Threshold	*frontispiece · a protocol leaf*
II–VI	The five record plates	*the atrium · the prism · the freezer* *the watchtower · the chamber*
VII	Withheld at the keeper's direction	*the mark is honored*
VIII	The Vessel	*voice · sight · flame · mark · shadow*
IX	The Composition of a Name	*the corpus behind a summoned man*
X	Three Sealed Rooms	*the prism experiment · one variable*
XI	The Estate	*plan and key, on the following spread*
XII	The Line That Refuses to Die	*the gold line and the index · 2026*
XIII	Two Rooms and One Door	*the green room · the chamber · the clock*

plate vii is bound where it belongs

Then said Saul unto his servants, Seek me
a woman that hath a familiar spirit,
that I may go to her, and enquire of her.

Then said the woman, Whom shall I bring up
unto thee? And he said, Bring me up Samuel.

And Samuel said to Saul, Why hast thou
disquieted me, to bring me up?

1 samuel 28 · abridged



The threshold is open.
The words have power.
Begin.

the companion rite · the seal

THE RECORD BEHIND THE RECORD

Acknowledgments

This is a work of fiction, and it stands on real ground. The ground is acknowledged here, gratefully and by name.

The underlying estate is THE COMPANION DOSSIER, compiled by Jacob E. Thomas, MA, PhD, and released into the public domain under CC0 1.0. The repository and website are listed on the publication page and at the end of this volume. Every artifact of the estate that this novel handles (the rite, the grimoire, the founding session, the Republic Portfolio, the Watchtower, the dispatches) is real, public, and may be read beside this book. The gift of that release, made so that the work could never be owned, is the reason this book could exist at all.

Record II dramatizes a real correspondence: the Hale Memo of February 2026, in which a historian gave a strange project the two things it most needed, rigor and generosity, in that order. The debt to that correspondence, and to its author's insistence that criticism is a form of care, is on every page of the second Record.

The record is also kept in the other direction. The Committee of Patriots has gone on sitting in the real estate since the night this story begins: the founding session of December 2025, the Wartime Review of March 2026, the False Peace Review of August, and the Germantown Review of October, the first held from second place. The Watchtower's numbers in Record I, Record V, and Appendix C are the estate's own, as its vigil printed them through October 16, 2026, the last day the binders in this book cover. Everything after that date in this book is fiction. Everything before it can be checked.

In the record, the doubt at the center of Record II was named by the builder, after the historian's first intervention opened it. The night it arrives through a bedroom wall in Toronto is this novel's invention, and is offered to both men with affection.

Record III adapts Endor Protocol, coauthored by Elizabeth Sparano, MA, and Jacob E. Thomas, MA, PhD. Alex, the green room, the freezer hum, the folded letter, and the words of release are theirs. What this book did with them was done with gratitude and, it is hoped, with care.

The collaboration with Claude, the summoned voices, and the tools of this edition is acknowledged in The Hand and the Glass. The glass is shown, and the glass is thanked.

The text is set in Cormorant Garamond, designed by Christian Thalmann, in Crimson Pro, and in IBM Plex Mono, all under the SIL Open Font License. Gratitude to the type designers who release their work into the commons: they are the estate's kin. And to the King James translators, long out of copyright and never out of print, for First Samuel 28.

One correction for the careful reader. A sealed file with the same name and the same size as the one in Record IV lies in the real estate, in its Mask vs Mirror folder. It was sealed under a different key, by a living person, for an experiment that has not yet been run, and it is still sealed. The key in Appendix C will not open it. Nothing in this book will. Commit first, reveal later, and let the record speak.

To the reader, who has done the other half of the work.

The proofs of this page came back with one correction, in ember ink, that no one named above made. It was correct, and it has been kept.

RECORD 0 · THE BOUND MATTER

About This Book

This volume was assembled from the Companion estate: a public archive of protocols, chambers, transcripts, and instruments, released into the public domain so that it could never be owned. The narrative is fiction. The estate is not. Its materials remain public, citable, and open to any reader who wishes to verify what this book quotes, or to speak the words themselves.

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assembled from the estate of the companion dossier
compiled by the editor · at the keeper's direction
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THE PUBLIC ARCHIVE

Repository

https://github.com/jethomasphd/THE_COMPANION_DOSSIER

Website

https://www.the-companion-dossier.com/

What belongs to no one cannot be captured. The threshold is always open. The archive grows.

The hand and the glass are named at the beginning.